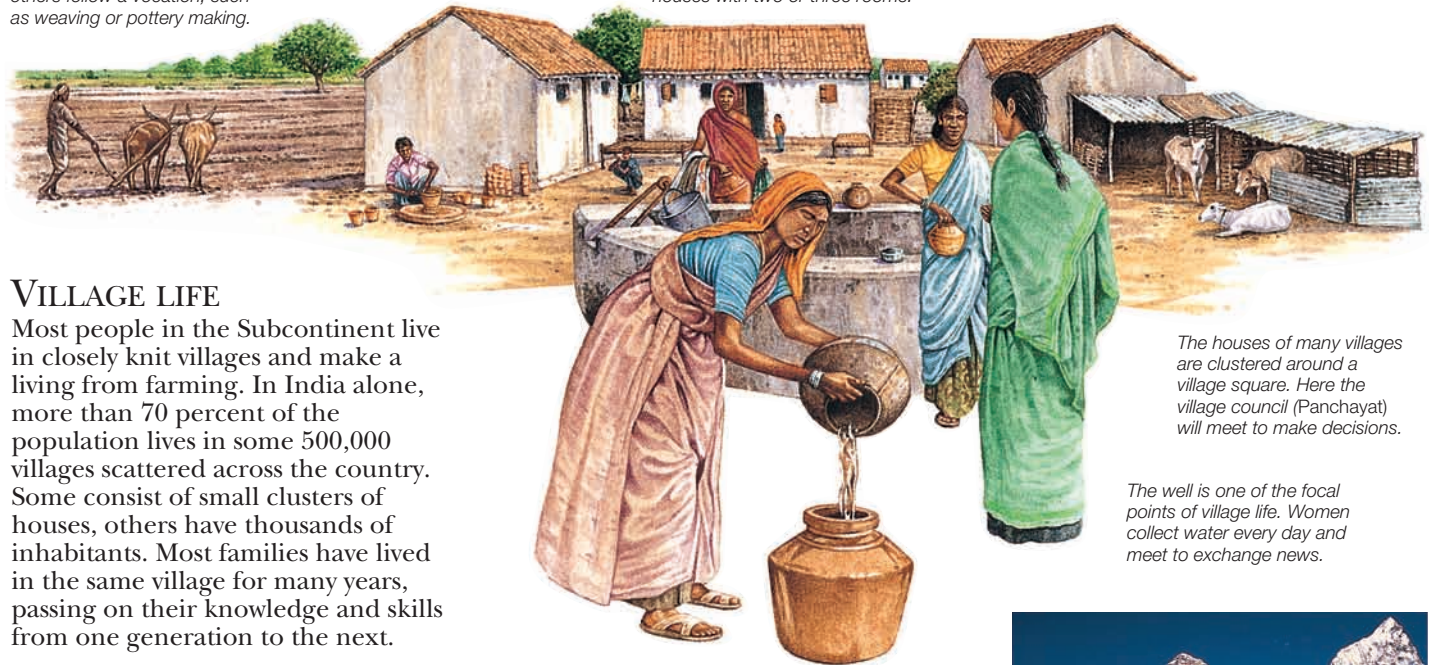


THE INDIAN SUBCONTINENT

FRINGED BY THE INDIAN OCEAN, the Arabian Sea, and the Bay of Bengal, and bordered to the north by the mighty Himalayas, the Indian Subcontinent covers a vast area. More than a fifth of the world's people live here. Dominated by India, the area also includes Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, the island of Sri Lanka, and the tiny state of Bhutan. The Subcontinent has a long and turbulent history and has been invaded many times. In the 19th and early 20th centuries, most of the area, aside from Nepal and Bhutan, was ruled by Britain. The landscape and climate of the Subcontinent vary greatly, with snowcapped mountains in the north, dry, sandy desert in the northwest, and hot, tropical rain forest in the south.

Most villagers are farmers, but others follow a vocation, such as weaving or pottery making.



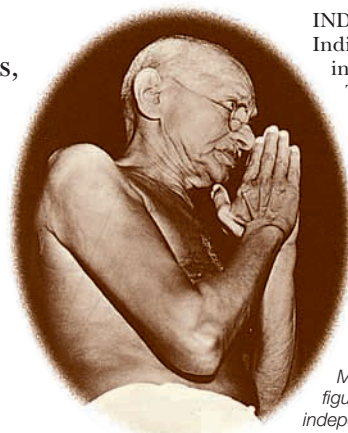
Most village people live in small houses with two or three rooms.

VILLAGE LIFE

Most people in the Subcontinent live in closely knit villages and make a living from farming. In India alone, more than 70 percent of the population lives in some 500,000 villages scattered across the country. Some consist of small clusters of houses, others have thousands of inhabitants. Most families have lived in the same village for many years, passing on their knowledge and skills from one generation to the next.

INDEPENDENCE
India became independent in 1947. The country was divided into Hindu India and the new Muslim country of Pakistan, split into West and East. In 1971, East Pakistan became the independent country of Bangladesh.

Mahatma Gandhi, a central figure in India's struggle for independence, believed in using peaceful methods to achieve his country's goals.



The houses of many villages are clustered around a village square. Here the village council (Panchayat) will meet to make decisions.

The well is one of the focal points of village life. Women collect water every day and meet to exchange news.



Because Bangladesh is flat and low-lying, it is particularly prone to flooding.

Southwest winds
(June to October)
Northeast winds
(November to February)



MONSOON

The climate of much of the Subcontinent is dominated by the monsoon winds, which bring rain to the area each summer. Farmers rely on this rainfall to water their crops. If the rains fail, they face ruin. Sometimes the rainfall is very heavy and causes terrible floods. Whole villages and fields of crops may be swept away.

SEASONAL WINDS

These winds blow from the southwest in summer and from the northeast in winter. As the summer winds sweep across the Indian Ocean, they pick up moisture, which turns into rain on reaching the hot, dry land.



TREKKING IN THE HIMALAYAS

Each year, thousands of tourists travel to Nepal to trek in the mountains. The Nepalese Himalayas include eight peaks more than 26,247 ft (8,000 m) high. The world's tallest mountain, Everest, stands on the border between Nepal and China. Many expeditions are accompanied by Sherpas. These Nepalese people are skilled climbers.